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The slaughtered camel

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A similar common way of recruiting extra labour is the requesting of “help” (kalmo). In this case the requirements for reciprocating are much less pronounced, but the investment of prestige is probably seen as higher. For instance, a too frequent request for kalmo, rather than goob, easily runs the risk the becoming interpreted as a display of parsimony. Alternatively, it may be seen as a result of a mystical misfortune that has struck the person, manifested by the fact that “he does not have children to help him”, as it was once expressed. These factors must certainly be at least part of the reason why kalmo working-parties are always much smaller than the goob ones. Like the goob, requests for kalmo put high demands on the perception of one’s network and miscalculations, or misuse, could prove detrimental.

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There are also some ways of asking for help on one’s field that are regarded as directly degrading. One of these is the galabey, “afternooning”. This is the name for help extended to a man who, working in the late afternoon on his field, calls upon bypassers returning from their own fields to work with him for a while. The work is usually done in a joking manner and the expectations for reciprocity are low. However, there is a double risk in requesting this form of help: as with the kalmo it can easily be regarded as parsimonious and it may also be seen as a misuse, or absence, of network and acquaintances.

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CONCLUSIONS

This chapter has drawn attention to the contrast between the segmentary lineage organization and the non-agnatic organization of the local community. How can the contrast between these two systems be understood? Should we perceive of it as being between a “model” or an “ideology” on the one hand and “social reality” or “social action” on the other?

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